STIVEN CATALYST

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MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.



PEOPLE

CONFLICT IN THE TEAM

Three kinds of conflict and what each costs, the hours it takes every week, five ways of handling it, what goes with stronger teams, and a card for the next dispute.

2.1 hours a week, on average, that employees in nine countries said they spent dealing with conflict at work.

CPP, 2008

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Every team disagrees: about priorities, about who does what, sometimes about each other. Which conflict costs a team, which can help it, and what can a manager do once it starts?

Researchers separate conflict about the task, about the relationship and about the process. Two meta-analyses, of 30 studies in 2003 and 116 in 2012, link personal friction with weaker teams, while for disagreement about the work the answer depends on the setting. In a 2008 survey in nine countries, employees said they spent 2.1 hours a week on conflict. Kenneth Thomas and Ralph Kilmann describe five ways of handling it, and a 2013 meta-analysis finds that how a team handles its differences matters at least as much as how much conflict it has.

Stiven Janaqi EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST

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HOW TO READ THIS ISSUE

Figure
Every figure has its source and year at the foot of its page.

Our reading
Where the editor interprets rather than the research, it says so.

Practice
The steps and the card are proposals to try, not research results.

COVER STORY

Not every conflict is the same

For years textbooks taught that disagreement about the work makes a team sharper and only personal friction harms it. In 2003 Carsten De Dreu and Laurie Weingart tested the idea across 30 studies.

01
Task
different views on the content of the work: ideas, opinions, decisions

02
Relationship
personal incompatibility, with tension, annoyance and animosity

03
Process
how the work gets done: who does what, and who is responsible

Their result went against the textbooks: task conflict went with weaker team performance (−0.23) about as much as relationship conflict (−0.22). In 2012 Frank de Wit, Lindred Greer and Karen Jehn repeated the test with 116 studies: relationship (−0.16) and process conflict (−0.15) still went with weaker performance, task conflict on average not at all (−0.01).

OUR READING

Disagreeing about the work helps a team only as long as it stays about the work.

Sources: Carsten K. W. De Dreu & Laurie R. Weingart, Journal of Applied Psychology, 2003; Tony L. Simons & Randall S. Peterson, Journal of Applied Psychology, 2000; Frank R. C. de Wit, Lindred L. Greer & Karen A. Jehn, Journal of Applied Psychology, 2012 (via De Wit's dissertation, ch. 2 (Leiden, 2013))

These are corrected correlations from correlational studies: they show a link without proving cause. Task and relationship conflict follow Karen Jehn (1995), as Simons and Peterson sum her up; process conflict follows de Wit and colleagues (2012).

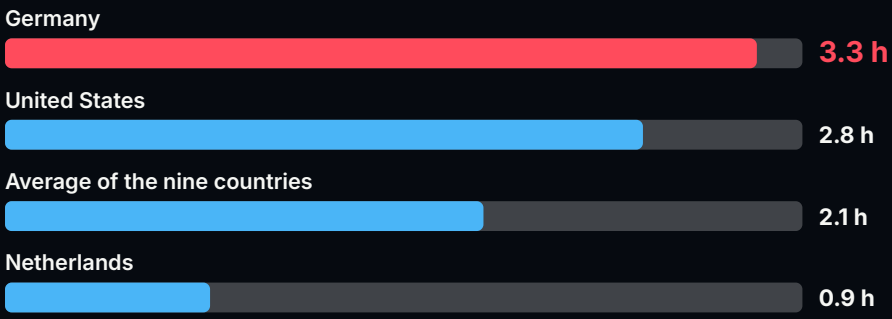
More in the essay Mistakes get lost between departments

THE NUMBERS

Two hours a week

In May 2008 CPP, then the publisher of the Thomas-Kilmann instrument, surveyed 5,000 full-time employees in nine countries in Europe and the Americas. The hours a week they said they spent dealing with conflict:

HOURS A WEEK SPENT DEALING WITH CONFLICT AT WORK, 2008



29%
deal with conflict always or frequently; in Germany, 56%

67%
have gone out of their way to avoid a colleague after a disagreement

22%
of non-managers think their managers handle conflict well; 31% of managers think so of themselves

Causes named most: clashes of personality and ego (49%), stress (34%), heavy workloads (33%). Only in Germany did stress come first (41%).

Source: CPP, Inc., with OPP and Fellipelli, 2008

Commissioned by a firm that sells conflict instruments and training; self-reports from 2008, the hours are estimates. For Albania we have no comparable figure.

THE MODEL

Five ways to handle a conflict

In 1974 Kenneth Thomas and Ralph Kilmann published an instrument of 30 pairs of statements. It places behaviour in a conflict on two dimensions: how far a person tries to satisfy their own concerns, and how far the other person's.

01	**Competing**	Assertive, not cooperative: you pursue your own concerns at the other person's expense.
02	**Collaborating**	Assertive and cooperative: you look for a solution that meets the concerns of both.
03	**Compromising**	Moderate on both: each side gives up part of what it wants.
04	**Avoiding**	Neither assertive nor cooperative: you pursue neither your concerns nor the other's, at least for now.
05	**Accommodating**	Cooperative, not assertive: you set your own concerns aside to meet the other's.

OUR READING

Most of us follow a habit rather than make a choice. Before a dispute, ask which mode the situation needs, whatever comes naturally to you.

Sources: Kenneth W. Thomas & Ralph H. Kilmann, Xicom, 1974 (via Kilmann Diagnostics); CPP, Inc., with OPP and Fellipelli, 2008

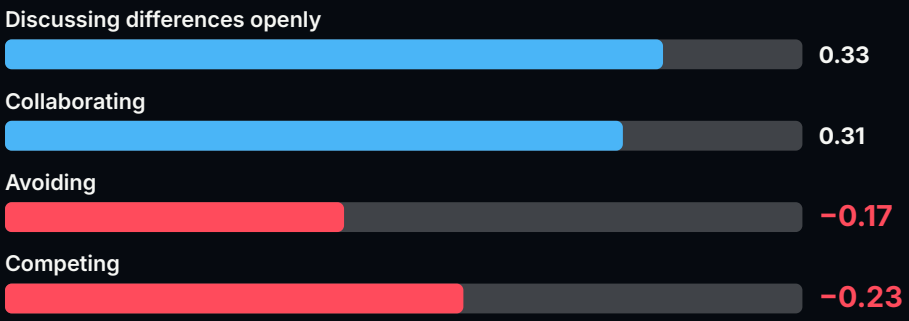
In Kilmann's words, everyone can use all five modes. The modes describe behaviour, not character. The instrument has been sold since 1998 by CPP, now The Myers-Briggs Company, which also commissioned the 2008 survey.

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

How the team handles it

In 2013 Leslie DeChurch, Jessica Mesmer-Magnus and Dan Doty pooled 45 studies with 3,218 teams. They separated how much conflict a team has from the way it handles it.

HOW A TEAM HANDLES CONFLICT AND ITS PERFORMANCE (CORRECTED CORRELATION)



Beyond the amount of conflict, the way of handling it explained another 13% of the differences in performance and in how members felt. Avoiding needs a closer look: in a 2001 study by Carsten De Dreu and Annelies van Vianen, teams that avoided personal friction functioned better than those that fought it out or tried to resolve it together.

OUR READING

Argue about the work in the open. A personal clash is often better taken out of the meeting.

Sources: Leslie A. DeChurch, Jessica R. Mesmer-Magnus & Dan Doty, Journal of Applied Psychology, 2013; Carsten K. W. De Dreu & Annelies E. M. van Vianen, Journal of Organizational Behavior, 2001 (via Abstract (UvA-DARE))

Correlations do not prove cause; bars show the size of the link, red where it is negative. Across studies, avoiding ranged from negative to slightly positive. The 2001 result is one field study of teams in complex, non-routine work.

HOW IT IS MEASURED

Ask what it is about

Most studies ask team members a few short questions from Karen Jehn's scale, some about the work and some about friction between people. Besides how much of each a team has, it matters whether the two move together.

Three questions for the team

1. Work: how often do people here disagree about the work being done?
2. Process: how often do we disagree about who does what?
3. Relationship: how much friction is there between people in the team?

−0.10
task conflict and performance, where task and relationship conflict were weakly linked

−0.35
the same link where the two were strongly linked (De Dreu & Weingart, 2003)

In 70 top management teams, Tony Simons and Randall Peterson found that trust changed how closely disagreement about the work went together with personal conflict. Their conclusion: trust is the key to gaining from task conflict without paying for relationship conflict.

Sources: Carsten K. W. De Dreu & Laurie R. Weingart, Journal of Applied Psychology, 2003; Tony L. Simons & Randall S. Peterson, Journal of Applied Psychology, 2000; Frank R. C. de Wit, Lindred L. Greer & Karen A. Jehn, Journal of Applied Psychology, 2012 (via De Wit's dissertation, ch. 2 (Leiden, 2013))

The questions are our wording, after the sample items reported for Jehn's scale; the process question follows de Wit and colleagues. Use the answers for the team, never to rate a person.

TOOL OF THE ISSUE

The conflict card

Fill it in alone before the conversation, then go through it with the other person. If the same dispute keeps coming back, treat it as a problem in the process and look for its cause with the 5 Whys sheet.

01 What it is about the work, the process (who does what) or the relationship

02 The facts we both accept what happened, without adjectives

03 My concern what I need, in one sentence

04 Their concern what I think they need; check it with them

05 The mode I choose compete, collaborate, compromise, avoid for now or accommodate, and why

06 What we agree who does what, by when, and the date we check it

Sources: Kenneth W. Thomas & Ralph H. Kilmann, Xicom, 1974 (via Kilmann Diagnostics); Frank R. C. de Wit, Lindred L. Greer & Karen A. Jehn, Journal of Applied Psychology, 2012 (via De Wit's dissertation, ch. 2 (Leiden, 2013))

Our proposal, after the five modes of Thomas and Kilmann (1974) and the three kinds of conflict in de Wit, Greer and Jehn (2012).

Open the tool: 5 Whys stivencatalyst.com/tools/five-whys/

SOURCES AND METHOD

Every figure has a source.

The figures in this issue come from the sources below. The year shows how recent each one is.

Task Versus Relationship Conflict, Team Performance, and Team Member Satisfaction: A Meta-Analysis
Carsten K. W. De Dreu & Laurie R. Weingart, Journal of Applied Psychology, 2003
https://doi.org/10.1037/0021-9010.88.4.741

Task Conflict and Relationship Conflict in Top Management Teams: The Pivotal Role of Intragroup Trust
Tony L. Simons & Randall S. Peterson, Journal of Applied Psychology, 2000
https://doi.org/10.1037/0021-9010.85.1.102

The Paradox of Intragroup Conflict: A Meta-Analysis
Frank R. C. de Wit, Lindred L. Greer & Karen A. Jehn, Journal of Applied Psychology, 2012 · via De Wit's dissertation, ch. 2 (Leiden, 2013)
https://doi.org/10.1037/a0024844

Workplace Conflict and How Businesses Can Harness It to Thrive (CPP Global Human Capital Report)
CPP, Inc., with OPP and Fellipelli, 2008
https://img.en25.com/Web/CPP/Conflict_report.pdf

Thomas-Kilmann Conflict Mode Instrument
Kenneth W. Thomas & Ralph H. Kilmann, Xicom, 1974 · via Kilmann Diagnostics
https://kilmanndiagnostics.com/a-brief-overview-tki/

Moving Beyond Relationship and Task Conflict: Toward a Process-State Perspective
Leslie A. DeChurch, Jessica R. Mesmer-Magnus & Dan Doty, Journal of Applied Psychology, 2013
https://doi.org/10.1037/a0032896

Managing Relationship Conflict and the Effectiveness of Organizational Teams
Carsten K. W. De Dreu & Annelies E. M. van Vianen, Journal of Organizational Behavior, 2001 · via Abstract (UvA-DARE)
https://doi.org/10.1002/job.71

EDITORIAL METHOD

Each figure was checked for its year, its publisher and what it measures, in the full text where it could be opened. A source read only in a summary, an abstract or excerpts is marked “via”. A figure not confirmed in what was read is marked so on its page, or left out. The editor's interpretation is marked “Our reading”.



MANAGEMENT REVIEW

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Every issue, one management question, checked against the best research.

ALL ISSUES

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Edited by Stiven Janaqi, who answers for it; “the editors” in this publication means him. Its texts, translations, layout and the checking of figures against their sources are done in working sessions with Claude, an AI model by Anthropic.
stivencatalyst.com/how-this-is-made.html